

Codebook of Subnational Democracy Dataset

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Explanatory notes

The aim of this document is to present the coding and source of the variables processed for the federal countries of Latin America. These countries feature subnational democracy, understood as the possibility of electing executive authorities in provinces and states. To provide a better reference for the year in which each country to be coded begins, the following table is presented:

Table 1. Subnational Elections in Latin American Federal Countries

Country	Number of regional subnational units for election	Year of beginning of subnational elections (Name of Executive)	Regulations	Year of beginning of subnational elections (Name of Legislature)	Regulations	Coverage
Argentina	23 provinces	1983 (Gobernadores)	CPA (1983) Art. 5	1983 (Legislaturas Provinciales)	Regulation by each province	1983-2024
Brazil	26 states + Federal District (Brasilia) = 27 federative units	1986 (Governador)	CPB (1988) Art. 27 y 28	1986 (Assembleia Legislativa)	CPB (1988) Art. 27 y 28	1986-2024
Mexico	32 federative entities (31 states and Mexico City)	1917/1985 (gobernadores)	CPMX (1917) Art. 115	1917/1985 (congresos estatales)	CPMX (1917) Art. 116	1985-2024

Particularities of subnational democracy by country in Latin America

Argentina: Elections of governors and provincial legislatures have been held since the national organization in the 19th century, with each province establishing its own electoral regulations in their respective provincial constitutions. Although the Argentine provinces have been electing governors and provincial legislatures since the 19th century, it is relevant to note that after the military dictatorship (1976-1983), the democratic election of these authorities

resumed in 1983 with the return to constitutional governance. The regulations are contained in the National Constitution of 1853, with reforms in force, where Article 5 establishes provincial autonomy to organize their own electoral institutions and procedures. In 1983, the country held general elections at the national and provincial levels, which was an important milestone for the consolidation of democracy after the military regime. Since then, each province has continued to regulate its subnational elections autonomously.

Brazil: Both the governor and state deputies are elected simultaneously in subnational general elections, which occur every four years, coinciding with the presidential and national legislative elections for senators and federal deputies. A key consideration is that in 1982, direct elections for governors and state legislative assemblies were reestablished during the democratic transition process under the government of João Figueiredo. If we consider the beginning of democracy, it should be 1986 since it follows the presidential elections of that year. After that, there have been 9 electoral processes, with the last one being in 2022 and the next one scheduled for 2026.

Mexico: Since 1917, each state of the Mexican Republic has had the power to organize its own elections for governor and state congress, following a federalist system that grants political autonomy to the states. State elections are organized by the Local Public Electoral Bodies (OPLEs), under the supervision of the National Electoral Institute (INE). However, it is important to consider that while the election of governors and state congresses formally dates back to 1917, 1985 is considered a key milestone because it marks the beginning of true democratic competition at the subnational level, where the results were no longer guaranteed for the PRI. In the gubernatorial and local congressional elections of 1985-1988, there were important advances for the opposition, particularly for the National Action Party (PAN) in states such as Baja California, which marked a change in state political dynamics. Additionally, in the 1980s, important developments occurred such as the implementation of the Fiscal Coordination Law (Ley de Coordinación Fiscal, LCF).

Identification Variables in the Dataset

country_name

Coded country name identifier:

- ARGENTINA
- BRAZIL
- MEXICO

year

The database has different starting years for each country, as shown in Table 1.

state_name

Coded subnational unit name identifier.

region_name

Coded country region name identifier.

Executive Variables

head_name_national

Name of the Head of State (President).

Source: worldstatesmen.org and V-Dem

sex_head_national

Sex of the Head of State (President):

0 = Male 1 = Female

Source: Own elaboration

term_head_national

Period of national government in start and end date in format (day/month/year).

Source: V-Dem

years_nat_gov

Years of government of the head of the national government (president).

Source: worldstatesmen.org and V-Dem

reelec_nat_gov

Dichotomous variable that indicates the reelection of the head of the national government (president):

1 = Head of government has been reelected 0 = Opposite case

Source: Own elaboration

early_exit_nat

Dichotomous variable that indicates whether the person in the national executive position (President) left office early either because they went to another position, resigned, died, or was impeached:

1 = Early departure from office 0 = Opposite case

Source: Own elaboration

head_party_national

Political party of the head of the national government (president).

Source: worldstatesmen.org and V-Dem

ideo_party_national

Ideology reported by the political parties of the head of the national government divided into 4 categories (if blank, it is because the person was independent or did not have a political affiliation):

1 = Left 2 = Center left 3 = Center right 4 = Right

Source: As reported on the website of each of the political parties.

electoral_national_year

Dichotomous variable that identifies whether national elections were held during the year:

1 = Presidential election year 0 = Otherwise

Source: Electoral registries of each country: <https://www.argentina.gob.ar/dine>; <https://ine.mx/>; <https://www.tse.jus.br/#/>

head_name_sub

Name of Head of Subnational State (Governor).

Source: In Argentina, it is obtained from Andy Tow's data with what was reported by Tulia Falleti in mail dated 04/21/2023 to Ernesto Calvo and Agustina Giraudy. The rest of the data is self-reported.

sex_head_sub

Sex of the head of the subnational State (Governor):

0 = Male 1 = Female

Source: Own elaboration

term_head_sub

Period of subnational government in start and end date in (day/month/year) format.

Source: Electoral registers of each country: <https://www.argentina.gob.ar/dine>; <https://ine.mx/>; <https://www.tse.jus.br/#/>

change_head_sub

Dichotomous variable indicating the change of the head of the subnational government (Governor). This variable identifies any change, including when a person assumes office in case of early departure:

1 = Year in which the change of the head of the subnational government (Governor) started or occurred 0 = Opposite case

Source: Own elaboration

cumulative_changes_head_sub

Continuous variable that tracks from the beginning of coding the number of changes of the head of the subnational government (Governor) in the State. This variable identifies in an additive manner any change, including when a person assumes office in case of early departure.

Source: Own elaboration

years_sub_gov

Years in office of the head of the subnational government (Governor). The variable is coded according to the total time per election period that the incumbent has been in office. However, in cases of early exits, it is coded with the total time the person has been in executive office until the next election.

Source: Own coding based on information from the Electoral Bodies of each country.

early_exit_sub

Dichotomous variable that indicates whether the person in the subnational executive office left office early either by leaving for another office, resignation, death, or impeachment:

1 = Early departure from office 0 = Otherwise

Source: Own elaboration

reelec_sub_gov

Dichotomous variable indicating the reelection of the head of the subnational government (Governor):

1 = Head of government has been reelected 0 = Not reelected Empty cell = Missing data in the case of Mexico due to non-reelection

Source: Own elaboration

years_sub_gov_contin

Continuous years in which the head of the subnational government (Governor) has governed. This variable captures how many years in total the person has held the office of head of subnational government, even when there is turnover.

Source: Own codification based on information from the Electoral Bodies of each country.

head_party_sub

Political party of the head of the subnational government (Governor). If the cell is empty, it implies that the governor was independent or did not have a political affiliation.

Source: Own codification based on information from the Electoral Bodies of each country. Additionally, information for Argentina was reported by Tulia Falletti in a mail dated 04/21/2023 to Ernesto Calvo and Agustina Giraudy.

change_sub_gov_party

Dichotomous variable indicating the change of the party of the head of the subnational government (Governor). This variable identifies any change, even when a person assumes office in case of early exit:

1 = Change of party 0 = No change in the party of the executive in power

Source: Own codification based on information from the Electoral Bodies of each country.

cumulative_changes_party_sub

Continuous variable that tracks from the beginning of coding the number of changes in the party of the head of the subnational government (Governor) in the State. This variable identifies in an additive way any change, including when a person assumes office in case of early departure.

Source: Own codification based on information from the Electoral Bodies of each country.

years_sub_gov_party_contin

Continuous years in which the party of the head of the subnational government (Governor) has governed. This variable captures how many years in total the party headed by an individual has held the office of head of subnational government, even when there is turnover.

Source: Own codification based on information from the Electoral Bodies of each country.

ideo_party_sub

Ideology reported by the political parties of the subnational head of government divided into 4 categories (if blank, it is because the person was independent or did not have a political affiliation):

1 = Left 2 = Center left 3 = Center right 4 = Right

Source: As reported on the website of each of the political parties.

electoral_sub_year

Dichotomous variable that identifies whether subnational elections were held during the year:

1 = Year of regional elections for change of governor 0 = Otherwise

Source: Own codification based on information from the Electoral Bodies of each country.

cumulative_electoral_sub_year

Cumulative subnational elections in the state.

Source: Own codification

concurrent_sub_nat_election

Dichotomous variable that identifies whether elections were held during the year for subnational and national executive changes:

1 = If it is a year of regional elections for change of governor and national elections for presidency 0 = Otherwise

Source: Own codification based on information from the Electoral Bodies of each country.

alignment

Dichotomous variable that identifies whether there is alignment between the head of the national government and the head of the subnational government:

1 = If there is alignment between the head of the national and subnational government 0 = Opposite case

Source: Own identification and "Uneven Social Policies: The Politics of Subnational Variation in Latin America" by Sara Niedzwiecki, Online Appendix

Electoral Variables

Electoral Variables Subnational Executive

extraordinary_election

Dichotomous variable that identifies whether there was an extraordinary subnational executive election:

1 = If there is an extraordinary election 0 = Otherwise

Source: Information from the Electoral Bodies of each country

date_electoral_sub

Day on which the electoral process takes place in day/month/year format.

Source: Information from the Electoral Bodies of each country

voters_registered_sub

The total number of registered voters for the electoral process of the chief executive in the subnational state.

Source: Information from the Electoral Bodies of each country

total_voters_sub

The total number of people who voted during the process of electing the chief executive in the subnational state (includes votes for parties, blank and invalid votes).

Source: Information from the Electoral Bodies of each country

voter_ratio_sub

The proportion of people who voted during the electoral process (includes votes for parties, blank and null votes). It is obtained by dividing the total number of voters by the total number of eligible voters in the State for the election process of the Subnational Chief Executive.

Source: Information from the Electoral Bodies of each country

valid_votes_sub

The total number of votes that are valid for the subnational head of government vote according to the State Electoral Management Body.

Source: Information from the Electoral Bodies of each country

valid_votes_ratio_sub

The percentage of votes that are valid for the subnational head of government vote according to the State Electoral Management Body.

Source: Information from the Electoral Bodies of each country

invalid_votes_sub

The total number of votes that are invalid or void for the subnational head of government vote according to the State Electoral Management Body.

Source: Information from the Electoral Bodies of each country

invalid_votes_ratio_sub

The percentage of votes that are invalid or void for the subnational head of government vote according to the State Electoral Management Body.

Source: Information from the Electoral Bodies of each country

votes_candidate_winner

The total number of votes received by the winning candidate in the subnational head of government vote according to the State Election Management Body.

Source: Information from the Electoral Bodies of each country

winner_candidate_ratio

The percentage of votes received by the winning candidate in the subnational head of government vote according to the State Electoral Management Body.

Source: Information from the Electoral Bodies of each country

second_place_votes

The total number of votes received by the second-place candidate during the subnational head of government vote according to the State Election Management Body.

Source: Information from the Electoral Bodies of each country

second_place_ratio

The percentage of votes received by the second-place candidate during the subnational head of government vote according to the State Electoral Management Body.

Source: Information from the Electoral Bodies of each country

last_place_votes

The total number of votes received by the last-place candidate during the subnational head of government vote according to the State Election Management Body.

Source: Information from the Electoral Bodies of each country

last_place_ratio

The percentage of votes received by the last-place candidate during the subnational head of government vote according to the State Election Management Body.

Source: Information from the Electoral Bodies of each country

margin_victory_exe

Measured as $v1 - v2$, where $v1$ is the percentage of votes for the winning gubernatorial candidate, and $v2$ is the percentage of votes for the second-place candidate.

Source: Information from the Electoral Bodies of each country

num_parties_executive_election_contest

Number of parties participating in the vote for subnational head of government according to the State Election Management Body.

Source: Information from the Electoral Bodies of each country

ENP

The indicator measures the effective number of parties competing in gubernatorial elections based on the Laakso and Taagepera (1979) index.

Source: Information from the Electoral Bodies of each country

Electoral Variables Subnational Legislative**cameral_sub_leg**

Dichotomous variable indicating the number of chambers in the sub-national legislature

THIS VARIABLE IS OF INTEREST IN CONSIDERING THAT THE DATA CAPTURED WILL BE BASED ON THE LOWER OR SINGLE CHAMBER.

1 = Unicameral

2 = Bicameral

Source:

date_electoral_sub_leg

Day on which the subnational legislative electoral process takes place in day/month/year format.

Source:

voters_registered_sub_leg

The total number of registered voters for the legislative electoral process in the subnational State.

Source:

total_voters_sub_leg

The total number of people who actually voted during the legislative electoral process in the subnational state (includes votes for parties, blank and null votes).

Source:

ratio_voters_sub_leg

The percentage of people who actually voted during the electoral process (includes votes for parties, blank and null votes). It is obtained by dividing the total number of eligible voters by the total number of voters in the State for the electoral process of the subnational legislature.

Source:

valid_votes_sub_leg

The total number of votes that are valid for voting in the electoral process of the subnational legislature according to the State Electoral Management Body.

Source:

valid_votes_ratio_sub_leg

The percentage of votes that are valid for voting in the electoral process of the subnational legislature according to the State Electoral Management Body.

Source:

invalid_votes_sub_leg

The total number of votes that are invalid or void for voting in the subnational legislative electoral process according to the State Electoral Management Body.

Source:

invalid_votes_ratio_sub_leg

The percentage of votes that are invalid or void for voting in the subnational legislative electoral process according to the State Electoral Management Body.

Source:

votes_party_leg_winner

The total number of votes going to the political party with the highest number of seats in the subnational body according to the State Electoral Management Body.

Source:

ratio_party_leg_winner

The percentage of votes going to the political party with the highest number of seats in the subnational body according to the State Electoral Management Body.

Source:

votes_party_leg_second_place

The total number of votes going to the second-place political party during subnational legislative voting according to the State Electoral Management Body.

Source:

ratio_party_leg_second_place

The percentage of votes going to the second-place political party during subnational legislative voting according to the State Electoral Management Body.

Source:

votos_party_leg_last_place

The total number of votes going to the last-place political party during subnational legislative voting according to the State Electoral Management Body.

Source:

ratio_party_leg_last_place

The percentage of votes that go to the last-place political party during subnational legislative voting according to the State Electoral Management Body.

Source:

margin_victory_leg

Measured as $v1 - v2$, where $v1$ is the percentage of votes of the winning legislative party, and $v2$ is the percentage of votes of the second-place party.

Source:

electoral_sub_year_leg

Dichotomous variable that identifies whether subnational legislative elections were held during the year:

1 = year of regional elections for the subnational legislature.

0 = otherwise

Source: Own codification based on information from the Electoral Bodies of each country.

cumulative_electoral_sub_year_leg

Cumulative subnational legislative elections in the state.

Source: Own codification

concurrent_sub_nat_election_leg

Dichotomous variable that identifies whether elections for subnational executive and legislative change were held during the year, together with national elections:

1 = if it is a concurrent election year

0 = otherwise

Source: Own codification based on information from the Electoral Bodies of each country.

num_parties_legislative_election_contest

Number of parties participating in subnational legislative voting according to the State Electoral Management Body.

Source:

num_legislative_seats

Total number of seats in the lower or single chamber of the subnational state.

Source:

num_seats_legislative_government

Total number of seats in the lower or single chamber of the subnational state that are controlled by the party of the executive (no alliances, only the governor's party).

Source:

ratio_seats_legislative_government

Total percentage of seats in the lower or single chamber of the subnational state that are controlled by the party of the executive (without alliances, only the governor's party).

Source:

num_seats_legislative_opos

Total number of seats in the lower or single chamber of the subnational state that are controlled by the opposition (even if there are parties in alliance to oppose the subnational government).

Source:

ratio_seats_legislative_opos

Total percentage of seats in the lower or single chamber of the subnational state that are controlled by the opposition (even if there are parties in alliance to oppose the subnational government).

Source:

ENPL

The indicator measures the effective number of subnational legislative parties based on the Laakso and Taagepera (1979) index.

Source:

ENPL_ELEC

The indicator measures the effective number of subnational legislative parties that went to elections based on the Laakso and Taagepera (1979) index.

Source:

Demographic Variables**HDI****GDP****GDP_PC****POPULATION**